

FIELD TRIPS

The Loudoun County School Board believes that field trips can provide excellent educational experiences for students by enriching the curriculum and by making learning experiences from the classroom more meaningful. To be educationally beneficial, a field trip requires thoughtful selection, careful advanced preparation and opportunities to assimilate the experience during and following the trip. The purpose of this policy is to establish guidelines for off-campus instructional and student activity field trips that are extensions of academic, athletic, and other student activities.

A. Definitions.

1. Instructional Field Trip. Planned outings away from the school involving one or more students under the supervision of a field trip organizer to enrich and extend the classroom instructional program. Field trips may be required for certain courses. For optional field trips, if a student does not participate, the school will provide an appropriate educational alternative.

2. Student Activity Field Trip. Planned outings away from the school involving one or more students under the supervision of the field trip organizer in support of academic or athletic teams, performing groups, or other student activities. Student participation is encouraged yet not required by Loudoun County Public School (LCPS). Student activity field trips include trips related to interscholastic, co-curricular, and extracurricular activities.

3. Field Trip Organizer. One or more LCPS staff members are responsible for the organization and execution of a field trip.

4. Day Field Trips. Planned outings which begin and end during regular school hours.

5. Extended Day Field Trips. Planned outings which begin and/or end outside regular school hours.

6. Routine Field Trips. Does not present safety or liability exposures beyond those expected or experienced in the school or classroom (e.g., museum, planetarium, theater, historical site, etc.); includes both Day Field Trips and Extended Day Field Trips; does not include overnight or international travel; does not include extreme physical exertion activities or water-related activities.

7. Non-Routine Field Trips. Presents increased liability and risk exposure to student safety or to LCPS; includes physical exertion activities or water-related activities (e.g., risks not limited to ropes courses, amusement parks, swimming, boating, etc.); includes both Day Field Trips and Extended Day Field Trips; includes overnight or international travel with overnight lodging.

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8. International Field Trip. Planned outings under the supervision of the field trip organizer that involves travel outside the mainland of the United States and are for educational purposes. International field trips are related to interscholastic, co-curricular, or extracurricular activities and can include visiting a museum, participating in a conference or competition, gathering data for research, and visiting a place/s of interest or event. These are Non-Routine Field trips which present increased liability and risk exposure to student safety or to LCPS students and include travel with overnight lodging.

B. Factors to Consider for Proposed Field Trips. The following factors should be considered in proposing field trips:

1. The safety, accountability and supervision of students.
2. The value of the trip to the particular class or student activity.
3. The relationship of the field trip to a particular aspect of the curriculum.
4. The distance traveled.
5. The time away from the regular instructional program.
6. The availability of transportation.
7. The accessibility of the field trip for all students.
8. The overall field trip cost for the school and students.

C. Approval of Field Trips. Field trips will be approved by the school principal and the Department of School Leadership pursuant to this policy and [5070-REG](#), Field Trips.

1. Administrative approval must be obtained before commitments are made to students, parents, or commercial establishments. Instructional and student activity field trips will be appropriately planned and organized per [5070-REG](#), Field Trips.

2. Trips for activities governed by the Virginia High School League (VHSL) or the Virginia Music Education Association (VMEA) do not require approval on a trip-by-trip basis. Parent/Guardian permission for such trips may be obtained for the entire athletic season or school year.

3. International trips shall not be approved for elementary or middle school students.

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D. Financial Considerations. Funds may be appropriated to support instructional and student activity field trips. In addition, school activity funds, contributions, fundraising activities or student fees may be used to defray the cost of optional field trips. Student fees will not be charged for required field trips. Student fees charged for optional instructional field trips may not exceed the cost of the field trip. No student will be denied the opportunity to participate in an optional instructional field trip because of an inability to pay a fee.

E. Student Safety, Accountability, and Supervision. Student safety, accountability and supervision are of utmost importance during the field trip. Teachers, coaches and staff members may change schedules, limit the participation of individual students or take other appropriate actions to preserve the safety and well-being of all concerned, to maintain order and discipline and to achieve the purposes of the trip. For overnight field trips, no adult will share a room with a student unless that adult is the student's parent or legal guardian. All School Board policies and regulations, including those outlined in the Students' Rights and Responsibilities Handbook, are applicable during school-sponsored field trips. Upon return to school, appropriate student disciplinary action may be initiated based on any violations observed during the trip

F. Non-LCPS Sponsored Field Trips. LCPS does not endorse or accept responsibility for any non-LCPS trips for students, or any student trips which are not part of the instructional or student activity program. Employees are not permitted to solicit students for such trips through school resources. Employees who are involved with such trips must emphasize to any interested student/parent/guardian that such trips are strictly private enterprises and not affiliated with LCPS.

[Formerly 5-11 and Policy 5-12]

Adopted: 9/11/84

Revised: 12/13/88, 6/22/93, 6/28/11, 12/3/19

Current Revision: 6/24/25

Cross Refs: Regulation [5070](#), Field Trips; Policy [7520](#), Non-School Employment; Policy [8010](#), Fundraising; Policy [8205](#), Discipline Authority; Policy [8210](#), Introduction to Student Discipline; Policy [8265](#), Student Searches and Seizure; Policy [8350](#), Student Activities;